

The Bookmark That Bites

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Teeth Marks in Aisle Seven

The first victim was a paperback mystery novel.

It arrived at the returns desk on a Wednesday morning with a small, neat semicircle bitten out of the upper-right corner of page forty-seven, which Maya noticed because she was the one who had checked it out, and she was quite certain she had not done any biting.

"I don't bite books," she said, setting it on the desk with the expression she wore when a situation required stating the obvious.

SPARK scanned the damage. "Bite radius approximately four millimeters. Consistent with very small teeth. Possibly rodent."

"Possibly not rodent," Natalia said. She had picked up the book and was examining the page more closely. The bite was precise. Too precise. Rodents gnawed in ragged arcs, driven by hunger or anxiety or the general restlessness of being a rodent. This was different. This had the quality of intention. "This was bitten with purpose."

Alana arrived from the reference section, where she had been cross-referencing navigational charts for an unrelated project. She took one look at the page, set down her notebook, and picked up the book without asking because the situation clearly called for it.

"The depth is uniform across the arc," she said. "Something with very even bite pressure. And very small jaws. And—" She tilted the page toward the window light. "Some kind of fabric fiber. Here. Caught in the paper edge."

It was a thread. Dark red, very fine, the kind used for embroidery or decorative stitching.

Maya looked at it. "Books don't have threads."

"Most books don't," Natalia agreed.

SPARK processed all of this. "I have no record of a tooth-marked return in this library. However, I am now extending my search parameters." His antenna swept the direction of the stacks. "There are seventeen other books currently on the returns shelf awaiting processing."

They looked at the shelf. They looked at each other.

"I'll get the magnifying glass," Alana said.

She went. She came back. They examined all seventeen.

Three more had the same small, deliberate, perfectly arced bite: one on the corner of a page, one on a chapter heading, one in the exact center of the title page in a way that felt almost personal.

"Four bitten books," Maya said.

"Five," SPARK said quietly. He indicated the mystery novel she had borrowed. "I should note that the page which was bitten — page forty-seven — has a fold in the upper right corner. A dog-ear. The bite is precisely positioned where the fold begins."

They all looked at page forty-seven. The corner had, indeed, been folded down some time ago to mark a place — then folded back, but the crease remained.

Natalia looked at the other three damaged books.

Each one, examined carefully, had a dog-ear. Old, new, pressed flat, or still standing — but there. Every single bitten page had been folded at the corner by someone, at some point, to mark their place.

"Something," Natalia said, "is biting dog-ears."

The mystery novel seemed to shiver slightly in Maya's hands, which was almost certainly a draft from the ventilation system.

Almost certainly.

Chapter 2 — A Pattern of Puncture

Alana spent the remainder of Wednesday morning creating a spreadsheet.

This was not unusual. What was unusual was that the spreadsheet's headers read: BOOK TITLE / DATE RETURNED / DOG-EAR LOCATION / BITE COORDINATES / THREAD COLOR / APPROXIMATE TOOTH SIZE (mm).

By lunchtime she had entries for all four books. By three o'clock, after SPARK had combed the returns of the previous three weeks with his optical sensors, she had eleven entries. The thread color was always dark red. The tooth size was always between three and four millimeters. The bite was always on the dog-eared page, always on or immediately adjacent to the fold.

"It is extremely consistent," Alana said, tapping her pen against the notebook in the way that meant she was pleased with the data and concerned about what it implied. "Whatever is doing this is not random. It knows which page was folded. It finds that specific page. It bites that specific corner."

"That is either a very clever animal," Maya said, "or not an animal."

"The thread fiber suggests fabrication rather than biology," SPARK offered. "The thread is polyester-cotton blend, consistent with embroidery floss, which is used in sewing rather than occurring naturally in either organisms or the Labyrinth Library's standard furnishings."

"So it was made," Natalia said. "Someone made it."

"Or something made itself," Maya said, and when the others looked at her she raised both hands. "I am not saying that is what happened. I am saying we should not rule it out. This library contains a room where the walls rearrange shelves by subject every Thursday. It contains an aisle where the ink responds to honesty. Manufactured things behaving unexpectedly is not the least likely explanation in this building."

SPARK, who was himself a manufactured thing behaving with some frequency in unexpected ways, processed this with evident self-awareness. "Agreed. We should proceed without ruling out the possibility that whatever this is has a degree of autonomous motivation."

"It's motivated," Natalia said. "It bites dog-ears specifically. That is a motive."

"Dog-ears," Maya said, tasting the logic of it. "Dog-ears are when you fold the corner of a page instead of using a bookmark. Some people think it damages the book."

"It does create localized fiber stress along the fold axis," Alana confirmed.

"So something very small, very consistently made, with very precise teeth, is biting people who fold book corners."

"Penalizing them," Natalia said.

"Or warning them," SPARK said.

None of them said the next thought immediately, because the next thought was that there was a very simple word for the kind of object that lived in books, marked pages, and apparently had opinions about how readers treated the volumes in its care. A small, flat, decorative object. The kind children made in craft projects. The kind that slipped between pages and waited to be needed.

A bookmark.

"We need to see the stacks at night," Natalia said. "Whatever is doing this is doing it when no one is watching."

"The library closes at seven," Alana said.

"SPARK can stay after closing," Maya said.

SPARK's chest panel lit with what they had all come to recognize as the brightness of a task he found genuinely interesting. "I can have preliminary surveillance results by morning."

"No confrontation," Natalia said firmly. "Just observation."

"Of course," SPARK said, in the tone of someone who fully intended to also make detailed notes about confrontation opportunities, just in case.

Chapter 3 — SPARK's Report on the Matter

SPARK's report was eleven pages long, single-spaced, with diagrams.

The summary, which is what they read first, went like this:

At 9:47 PM, in the southwest corner of Aisle Seven (general fiction, surnames H through M), a small object approximately the size and dimensions of an adult human's index finger emerged from between pages 312 and 313 of a novel whose spine was labeled HENDERSON, G. The object was dark red. It moved with the locomotion of something that had practice at moving very quietly and very fast along shelf edges. It examined three books in quick succession by running itself along their spines in a motion consistent with reading the titles. Two books it passed over. The third it stopped at.

It pushed itself partway into the book. It found the dog-eared page. It bit it. Then it returned to HENDERSON, G., pushed itself back between pages 312 and 313, and went still.

The entire process took forty-three seconds.

"It lives in Henderson, G.," Maya said.

"Nests," Alana said. "Present tense."

"What is Henderson, G.?" Natalia asked.

SPARK had anticipated this question. He projected a small image: a mid-century adventure novel, somewhat faded, which had not been borrowed in six years. It was the kind of book that persisted on library shelves through sheer inertia — not popular enough to be much read, not old enough to be rare, simply present. The sort of book that became, over time, a kind of permanent resident.

"The book has been in this location for six years," SPARK confirmed. "It has not been checked out in that time. It is, in practical terms, unoccupied space."

"From the bookmark's perspective," Natalia said slowly, "it found an empty apartment."

"That is one way to describe it," SPARK said.

Maya was already heading for Aisle Seven. The others followed.

The book was where SPARK had shown them: mid-shelf, between two slightly taller neighbors, its spine bearing the modest font of someone who had published in 1967 and had not expected to be consulted about typography. Maya pulled it from the shelf.

She opened it to pages 312 and 313.

Between them, perfectly still in the way things are still when they know they have been found, was the bookmark.

It was small — about three inches long and half an inch wide, made of dark red cloth stitched around a stiffening

of thin cardboard. The stitching was uneven in a way that suggested it had been made by hand, by someone not yet expert at the task. Along its length, in careful block letters embroidered in gold thread:

CHOMP

And below that, slightly smaller, slightly crooked:

RESPECT THE BOOK OR FACE THE CONSEQUENCES

"That," Maya said, "is the most dramatic bookmark I have ever encountered."

Chomp, who had been absolutely motionless, opened two very small eyes.

They were red, which was probably not a coincidence, and they blinked with the deliberate slowness of something that had been awake much longer than anyone had noticed and was now deciding whether to be indignant or merely stern.

It opened its mouth.

Four tiny, perfect, pointed teeth gleamed in the aisle light.

"Hello," Natalia said, because someone had to.

Chapter 4 — First Words with Chomp

There was a long pause of the kind that happens when both parties to a conversation are establishing whether it is going to be a reasonable one.

Chomp assessed them. They assessed Chomp. SPARK, whose sensors were running at full capacity and who was experiencing what his internal logs would later describe as unprecedented data density for an eleven-centimeter object, remained very still so as not to startle anything.

"You found me," Chomp said.

Its voice was small — not squeaky, but compact, the way a voice gets when the body producing it is three inches long and contains a great deal of compressed opinion. It had the quality of something that had been waiting a long time for the right conversation and was not entirely sure this was it.

"We found you," Natalia agreed. She was holding the book very steady, Chomp still resting between its open pages, because she had the feeling that sudden movements would not help the situation.

"You're not going to scream," Chomp observed. It seemed slightly disappointed.

"Should we?" Maya asked.

"Most people do. There was a librarian in 1987 who screamed so loudly that someone in the periodicals section came to check. I was very nearly catalogued."

"You've been here since 1987?" Alana said. She had already opened her notebook.

"Longer," Chomp said. "I was placed in this library in the autumn of 1984. I have been in Henderson, G. since the spring of 1993, when the previous tenant was checked out and never returned." A tiny pause. "I believe they are in someone's attic in Northampton. I try not to think about it."

"Chomp," Maya said, reading the embroidered name. "Is that what you call yourself, or what someone called you?"

Chomp's small chest — visible only because it rose and fell with what was clearly a breath — expanded slightly with something that might have been pride. "I was named. By my maker. Who understood my purpose." Another pause. "Do you want to know about my purpose?"

"We do," said Natalia.

"Then stop letting people fold the corners of library books," Chomp said, "and I will have less to do, and we will have more time for conversation."

It was at this point that Maya, who had an opinion about dog-ears that she had held since the age of seven and had never had reason to defend against a small cloth vampire, opened her mouth.

"Actually," she said.

Chomp turned its red eyes on her.

"Dog-ears are not that bad," Maya said, because she was Maya and backing down from a position she believed in was not something she did without argument first. "Some books deserve to be folded. It means someone cared enough to mark their place. It means they were going to come back."

Chomp stared at her for three full seconds.

"Sit down," it said. "This is going to take a while."

SPARK, whose processing capacity was currently occupied with the question of whether a three-inch cloth bookmark could be said to have jurisdiction over anything and what the legal framework for that might look like in a library context, quietly activated his recording function.

He had a feeling this would be worth keeping.

Chapter 5 — The Rules According to Chomp

Chomp had rules. It was immediately clear that it had given the rules a great deal of thought, over a great many

years, in a great deal of quiet.

"Rule the First," it said, settling against the spine of Henderson, G. with the air of something that had delivered this speech before, or had at least rehearsed it extensively in the privacy of pages 312 and 313. "A book is not a note-pad. It is not a coaster. It is not a frisbee, which someone once used one as in 1991 and I still think about."

"The frisbee incident is in your memory?" Alana asked.

"Everything is in my memory," Chomp said. "I have been in this library for forty years. I have seen things."

"Rule the First was about note-pads," SPARK prompted.

"Yes. A book may be loved. It may be held, carried, read in the bath if extreme care is taken, read while eating if the eater is tidy, and read by torchlight under a duvet which does no structural harm to the book and considerable good to the reader. A book may be annotated in pencil, lightly, because pencil can be erased and belongs to the tradition of scholarly marginalia. It may be creased at the spine by a reader who holds it flat, which is not ideal but acceptable." Chomp's tiny voice took on weight. "What it may not be is dog-eared. Folding the corner creates a permanent stress fracture in the page fiber. After enough foldings, the corner weakens and eventually tears. The book is shortened. The corner disappears. The page is permanently smaller."

"There are bookmarks," Alana said. "That is their function."

"Exactly!" Chomp said, with a small but emphatic gesture that involved its entire body. "That is precisely my point. Bookmarks exist. I exist. There is no excuse."

"Some people don't have a bookmark to hand," Maya said.

"Then they use a receipt. A bus ticket. A leaf if they're outside. A piece of folded paper. Their finger, if they're only leaving for a moment." Chomp looked at her. "What they do not do is fold the page."

"What if they forget their bookmark?"

"Then they memorize the page number."

"What if they're not good at memorizing?"

Chomp paused. It was the pause of something encountering a counterargument it had considered and had a response to, but which required a moment of genuinely thinking about its delivery. "Then they try harder," it said, but less certainly than before.

"Or," Maya said carefully, "we could find a solution that involves less biting."

Chomp was quiet.

"She means a compromise," Natalia said.

"I know what she means," Chomp said. "I've been considering compromises for forty years. I tried a polite note system in 1998. I tucked a small handwritten card in every book that said PLEASE USE A BOOKMARK and drew a small illustration of myself for clarity. Do you know how many people read those notes?"

"How many?" SPARK asked.

"One. She thought I was a decorative insert from the publisher and kept me as a curiosity." Chomp's voice had reached the specific register of someone who has suffered and would like that suffering acknowledged. "I spent eight months in someone's junk drawer in Bristol."

"That does sound bad," Natalia said, genuinely sympathetic.

"It was near a battery that was leaking," Chomp said, with great dignity. "Let us never speak of it again."

"We want to help," Alana said. She was looking at her notebook with the careful expression she wore when a problem was beginning to yield a structure. "But the biting is not working, is it. You've been biting for years and there are still dog-ears."

Chomp did not answer immediately.

"No," it said, at last. "It isn't working."

The admission settled into the aisle quietly, with the heaviness of something that had taken forty years to say.

Chapter 6 — Maya's Case for the Dog-Ear

They moved to the reading alcove near the end of Aisle Seven, because it had chairs, and because conducting negotiations — even early-stage ones with a small cloth vampire — on a standing basis seemed unnecessarily formal.

Chomp rode on the open book, which Maya carried. Alana had her notebook. SPARK perched at the end of the table in his observation posture. Natalia sat cross-legged, which was her thinking position.

"Before we get to solutions," Maya said, "I want to make a case for dog-ears."

"You've already begun making it," Chomp said, from its position on page 312. It had folded its tiny arms, which was impressive given its dimensions.

"I've been dog-earing books since I was six," Maya said. "Not all books. Not carelessly. But some of them. The ones that hit me so fast I didn't stop to find a bookmark. The ones I was reading on the bus. The ones I was reading in the waiting room at the doctor's and my mum called my name right in the middle of a sentence and I had to go and I folded the corner so I wouldn't lose that sentence."

"You could have—"

"Memorized the page number. I know. But the point isn't the system. The point is urgency. Dog-ears happen when you're so inside a book you haven't thought about the mechanics of it. When the reading is happening faster than the bookmarking." Maya looked at Chomp directly. "A dog-eared book is not a disrespected book. It's a book that was read in a rush, which means someone couldn't wait."

Chomp said nothing. But its arms had uncrossed slightly.

"The worst thing you could do to a book," Maya went on, "is not read it. Not care enough to fold a corner. Not care enough to open it. Not care enough to sit somewhere and spend time in it. Dog-ears are evidence of caring, even if the method isn't perfect."

"The page fiber still—"

"I know about the page fiber. Alana told me. And you're right, technically." Maya leaned forward. "But here's the thing, Chomp. What would you prefer? A book with a folded corner that's been read twelve times by twelve different people who all cared about it? Or a book with perfect, pristine pages that no one has ever loved enough to open?"

The silence in the alcove was the kind that happens when something small and significant is being decided.

Natalia was watching Chomp. She could have sworn — and later, she would have sworn — that something shifted in the small red eyes. Not a change of position, not a blink, but a quality. Like a door that had been firmly closed admitting, for the first time in many years, a small amount of light.

"The book in Bristol," Chomp said, very quietly. "In the junk drawer."

"Yes?"

"It was a paperback. Someone had dog-eared nearly every chapter." A pause. "I was furious. For eight months I had nothing to do but be furious about it." Another pause. "And also read it. Because it was there and I was there and there was nothing else." The voice went quieter. "It was extremely good."

Maya did not say anything.

"That is not a concession," Chomp said immediately. "I am not conceding the principle. Dog-ears are technically damaging. This is established science."

"Yes," Maya said.

"I am merely acknowledging that the matter is not entirely simple."

"It rarely is," Natalia said.

Chomp sat very still on page 312 and appeared to be thinking thoughts it had not thought before, which was, after forty years in the same library, a notable experience.

Chapter 7 — Stakeout in the Stacks

The problem, as Alana outlined it the following morning, was not Chomp.

Chomp had a point, and the point was about principle, and principles were worth engaging with even when they were delivered via small cloth teeth at three in the morning. The problem was the scale. One very old, very principled bookmark could not teach four hundred and twelve library patrons to use bookmarks more reliably.

"What it needs," Alana said, drawing a grid in her notebook that divided the problem into component parts in the way she always did, which usually alarmed people who didn't know her and reassured people who did, "is a system. Not biting. Not polite notes. A system that actually works."

"I'll stay in the stacks again tonight," SPARK said. He had filed his previous night's report with the efficiency of something that had very much enjoyed doing it and wanted to do it again. "Observation only. I want to understand the full extent of the dog-ear situation before we design the response."

"I'm coming too," Maya said.

"The library closes at seven," Natalia said.

"SPARK is allowed to stay after closing. I'll stay with SPARK."

"That seems like it will result in you sleeping on the floor of Aisle Seven," Alana said.

"I'll bring a blanket," Maya said, with the serenity of someone who had already thought this through.

In the end they all stayed, because none of them found it reasonable to send Maya and SPARK on a vampire-bookmark stakeout alone, and because Natalia had brought three extra blankets in a bag that was suspiciously pre-packed, suggesting she had anticipated this outcome.

They set up in the reading alcove near Aisle Seven. Alana brought a thermos. SPARK dimmed his displays to their lowest setting, which was approximately the brightness of a firefly having a very calm day. Chomp, informed of the plan, had retreated to Henderson, G. and informed them it would not emerge before midnight because it had standards.

"What standards?" Maya had asked.

"I don't bite before midnight," Chomp said, in the tone of someone stating something obvious. "Daylight hours are for contemplation."

"That is genuinely one of the most dramatic things anyone has ever said in this library," Maya said.

"It's true, though," SPARK said. "In forty years of surveillance data, all biting incidents have occurred between midnight and five AM."

"I sleep in the afternoons," Chomp said. "I'm not a monster."

By eleven o'clock that night, two of them were asleep and one was nearly there. SPARK was awake, which was his natural state, running quiet scans along the stacks with the patience of something that did not require entertainment to remain attentive. Chomp had emerged from Henderson, G. shortly after the clock in the main hall struck twelve and was currently moving along Aisle Seven with the crisp efficiency of a very small being with a job to do.

SPARK observed. He counted eleven books examined. Seven passed over. Four stopped at. Three bitten.

The fourth — a battered young adult novel with multiple dog-eared pages — Chomp stopped at, examined, and then sat on top of for nearly two minutes without biting.

SPARK zoomed his optics.

The book had at least eight dog-eared pages. The corners were folded at different angles, in different states of wear, clearly by different hands over many years. Chomp moved across the cover slowly, pressing itself flat in the way of something thinking hard.

Then it did something SPARK had not seen before and had not expected.

It sat in the center of the cover and stayed there until the clock struck two AM.

Just sat. Not biting. Not moving. Just present.

SPARK flagged the anomaly in his notes and filed it for morning discussion, under a heading he labeled: CHOMP — POSSIBLE SOFTENING.

Chapter 8 — The Rogues' Gallery of Borrowers

They gathered the dog-ear evidence the next morning in a methodical way.

Alana and SPARK spent three hours going through the returns shelf and the reshelving cart with the magnifying glass and the spreadsheet, identifying every book that had arrived with a dog-eared page in the past six weeks. There were forty-three. Forty-three books, from forty-three borrowers, who had at some point folded a corner rather than reaching for a bookmark.

"Forty-three," Chomp said, from its perch on the edge of the desk, where it had been invited to sit as a working consultant on the grounds that it had the most local expertise. "Forty-three since I last counted. In six weeks."

"You can't bite all of them," Maya said.

"I have been trying," Chomp said. "For forty years."

"And the dog-ears have not decreased," Alana said, reading from her spreadsheet. "In fact, from the data I can

compile from return records, the rate has been roughly consistent since the 1990s. The biting is not working as a deterrent."

Chomp was quiet for a moment. "I know," it said.

"Some of these borrowers," Natalia said, picking up the list, "are children. Some are very young, from the lower shelves and the picture book section. Some are very old, from the large-print section, where the corners are probably being folded because the print is small and the pages don't move easily." She put the list down. "Some of them are folding corners in hospital waiting rooms. We can tell from the holds section. And train carriages — the returns from the mobile library van have the highest dog-ear rate."

The word hospital sat in the air for a moment.

"Trains and hospitals," Maya said. "Not ideal places to hunt for a spare bookmark."

Chomp said nothing. But it was the saying-nothing of something that was listening more carefully than its face showed.

"The problem," Alana said, setting down her pen in the way she did when she had reached the structural center of a problem, "is not that the borrowers don't care. Several of these books have careful annotations in pencil, beautiful handwriting, little stars beside the best passages. These are not people who don't care about books. They just didn't have a bookmark." She paused. "What if they had one?"

"They have one. Every library has them. The desk gives them out."

"What if the bookmark came with the book? Already inside it? What if every book that left this library had a bookmark tucked into the front cover?"

The silence this time was a different kind — the silence of an idea landing cleanly.

SPARK ran a quick calculation. "The library loans an average of three hundred and forty books per week. Bookmarks can be produced for approximately four cents each at scale. Annual cost: seven hundred and eight dollars, plus printing." He paused. "Within standard promotional materials budget."

"We're talking about bookmarks," Chomp said, and its voice had shifted into something harder to read — something that was trying to be flat but was not entirely succeeding. "You want to give everyone a bookmark."

"We want to make it so easy to use a bookmark that dog-earing doesn't occur to anyone," Natalia said. "Not because it's forbidden. Because there's already something better to hand."

Chomp looked at the list of forty-three borrowers. It looked at the spreadsheet. It looked at the column Alana had labeled DOG-EAR MOTIVATION (SPECULATIVE), which contained entries like: PROBABLE HOSPITAL / TRAIN / CHILD / ELDERLY / READING UNDER DUVET and one entry which simply said POSSIBLY JUST ENTHUSIASTIC.

"If this works," Chomp said, with the caution of something that had been disappointed by solutions before, "the biting becomes unnecessary."

"Yes," Natalia said.

"I would have nothing to do," Chomp said.

"You would have a different thing to do," Maya said. "We've been thinking about that."

Chomp's red eyes moved from Maya to Natalia to Alana. Then to SPARK, who gave a small, corroborating nod.

"There is something you should know first," Natalia said. "About who made you. We found something, last night, while you were doing your rounds." She looked at Alana.

Alana opened her notebook to the page where she had copied it out, very carefully, in her precise handwriting.

"SPARK found it," she said. "Sewn into your lining."

Chapter 9 — What Was Sewn Inside

It was SPARK who had found it, in the small hours of the stakeout, after Chomp had done the unusual thing of sitting still on the cover of the battered young adult novel without biting.

While Chomp slept — for it did sleep, pressed flat between pages 312 and 313, unmoving, apparently deep in whatever it was that bookmarks dreamed about — SPARK had conducted a gentle scan of its structure. Not invasive. Boundary-respecting. The kind of scan that reads surface information and nothing more.

He had detected an anomaly in the lower third of Chomp's body: a slight thickening of the cardboard stiffener, as if something had been placed between the layers before the final stitching went in. Paper, from the density reading. Not thick. A small square. The kind of size used for notes.

He had flagged it but not acted on it.

Now, in the morning, they told Chomp.

Chomp was still for a long time. Then it said: "I have always felt heavier at the bottom than is strictly accounted for by my dimensions."

"We didn't look at it," Natalia said. "We want your permission. If you want to know what it says."

Another long pause.

"I do," Chomp said.

It was Alana who removed the paper, with the tweezers from her toolkit and the steadiness of someone who had

once extracted a pressed flower from a 300-year-old binding without tearing a petal. The stitching at Chomp's lower edge was very gently loosened. The square of paper — small, folded twice, slightly yellowed at the edges — slid free.

She unfolded it.

The handwriting was a child's: rounded letters, uneven spacing, the h's and k's too tall, the line wandering slightly uphill toward the right margin in the way of someone who hadn't yet learned to keep their hand level.

Alana read it aloud.

To whoever you are: My name is Frankie. I made this bookmark because I love books more than almost anything and I don't want them to get hurt. I know folding corners is bad but I used to do it all the time until I read about how it damages the page and then I felt really bad about all the books I had done it to. I made Chomp to help other people not do it. I put him in the library because I can't watch all the books myself. Please do not be too scared of his teeth. He is only small. He is very serious about his job but I made him with love because books deserve someone to look after them.

— Frankie, age 9

P.S. Please give him a good home.

The reading alcove was very quiet.

SPARK's display had gone to a single steady amber — the color he produced, they had learned, when something was affecting him in a way that did not have a ready diagnostic category.

Maya said, very softly: "Frankie was nine."

"She made you to protect books," Natalia said to Chomp. "Because she loved them. And she put you in the library because she couldn't do it herself."

Chomp was perfectly still.

After a long moment it said, in a voice that was smaller than usual but not less sure of itself: "I knew she was good. I don't remember her face. But I know she was good." A pause. "The thread she used to make me — it was her best embroidery thread. The kind she saved."

"Dark red," Alana said.

"Dark red," Chomp agreed.

Maya reached out very carefully and placed one finger alongside Chomp — not touching, just close. A gesture of proximity. Of being there.

"She wanted someone to look after the books," Natalia said. "You've been doing it for forty years. You've done the job."

"I haven't stopped the dog-ears," Chomp said.

"No," Natalia said. "But maybe that's not the only way to look after something."

She picked up Frankie's note with great care. She folded it back along its original creases. She offered it to Chomp.

Chomp accepted it. Tucked it back into the hollow at its own base, which it could, it turned out, access from the inside. Then it was quiet for a very long time, and none of them disturbed it.

Outside, the library opened its doors to the morning.

Chapter 10 — The Treaty Talks

The negotiations were conducted the following afternoon, in the reading alcove, with SPARK serving as official recording secretary.

Chomp sat on its own volume — Henderson, G. — which it had requested be brought as a neutral territory and which they had agreed was reasonable. It had also requested, with some dignity, that it be allowed to speak first.

"I have three conditions," Chomp said.

"We also have conditions," Maya said.

"I am aware. One speaks first and the other responds. Basic diplomacy."

"You've read about diplomacy?" Alana asked.

"I've been in a library for forty years," Chomp said. "I've read about everything. Condition the First: the library must place a bookmark in every book that goes out on loan. No exceptions. Not just the fiction. The oversized picture books, the reference books on short loan, the DVDs — everything that has a page or a cover must leave with a bookmark."

"Agreed," said Natalia.

"Condition the Second: the bookmarks must have something worth reading on them. Not just the library logo and opening hours. Something real. A short poem, or a fact, or a question worth thinking about. Because a boring bookmark goes in the bin and is no protection at all."

"Also agreed," said Alana, who had been hoping someone would say this.

"Condition the Third." Chomp paused. "I want a window."

They looked at each other.

"I have been living in Henderson, G. for thirty-one years," Chomp said. "Page 312 faces the spine. It is dark. I have never asked for anything, but I am asking for this: a place with a view."

"A window," Maya said. "In the library."

"Near a window," Chomp clarified. "A book near a window. So that on the nights when I come out to check the shelves, and on the mornings when I wake before the library opens, I can see whether it is raining."

The silence was the slightly undone silence of people who had not expected this to be the most affecting of the three conditions.

"We can do that," Natalia said quietly.

"Good," Chomp said. "Now. Your conditions."

They had three as well.

First: no biting without a warning. If a book came back with a dog-ear, Chomp could insert a note — a formal note, properly written, citing the page in question — before any teeth were involved. A first offense received a note. A repeated offense from the same borrower received a note and a small red thread tied around the corner by way of formal caution. Only a third offense would involve biting, and even then, only a very gentle one, more of a nibble, communicative rather than punitive.

Chomp considered this for approximately four seconds. "Reasonable," it said.

Second: Chomp would assist with the bookmark project. It had, they pointed out, forty years of experience knowing which pages people most commonly marked in which books, which genres had the highest dog-ear rates, and which sections needed the most intervention. That knowledge was valuable.

"I would need writing implements," Chomp said.

"SPARK can print at whatever scale you need," Alana said.

"Then yes," Chomp said.

Third: they would make sure Frankie's note was preserved. Properly. Archived. With a copy kept somewhere safe.

Chomp was quiet for a long time.

"There may be no way to find Frankie," it said finally. "She would be about fifty now. She wrote the note in 1984 and I never saw her again."

"We know," Natalia said. "But her note should be kept. Regardless."

"Yes," Chomp said. "It should."

SPARK printed a formal copy of the treaty in the smallest font his printer could manage — he had suggested full-size and Chomp had given him a look — and presented it on a single index card. Chomp pressed one corner of its body against the signature line, leaving a small but definite impression in the paper.

Maya signed for the sisters.

SPARK dated it.

"This has been," Chomp said, reading the finished document with the careful attention of someone who fully intended to hold everyone to its terms, "the most productive conversation I have had in forty years."

"You've been alone for forty years," Maya said. "That might be part of the problem."

Chomp looked at her. Then it looked at Henderson, G., which had been its home for three decades.

"Perhaps," it said.

Chapter 11 — The Peace of the Pages

The bookmark program launched on a Thursday.

Alana had designed them: plain white card, library logo in one corner, a small printed fact on the back, rotating each month. The first batch said: A single page of paper can be folded a maximum of seven times regardless of size. Mathematicians have tried for years to beat this. They cannot. Chomp had reviewed the selection of facts with what could only be described as editorial seriousness, rejecting two options as insufficiently interesting and suggesting the paper-folding fact specifically, which everyone agreed was excellent.

There were also, on the very first batch, a small dark red bookmark-shaped illustration in the lower right corner, with CHOMP printed in tiny gold letters beneath it.

"Is that me?" Chomp had asked, when SPARK showed it the proof.

"It is," Maya said. "A kind of mascot. A reminder of what bookmarks are for."

Chomp studied the illustration for a long time. "The ears are slightly too large," it said.

"The ears are accurate," SPARK said.

"They are somewhat large," Chomp said, in the tone of something that had decided to accept rather than debate this.

The bookmarks went into every outgoing book starting Thursday morning. By Friday, three borrowers had mentioned them to the front desk — all positively, two with follow-up questions about the paper-folding fact. By

the following Wednesday, return rates were up slightly, which the head librarian attributed to unclear causes and which Alana attributed to people returning books because they were enjoying the bookmark and wanted another.

The dog-ear rate did not drop to zero. Chomp had not expected it to. People in hospital waiting rooms still sometimes folded corners, and people on trains, and children in the middle of exciting chapters. But the rate dropped, measurably, over the first month. And when a book came back dog-eared now, Chomp left a note — a very small note, in writing that SPARK had printed at point-six font on a thin strip of paper, which read:

I noticed a folded corner on page [X]. The bookmark enclosed was meant for exactly this moment. No harm done this time. — C.

The notes, the librarians discovered, were being kept by borrowers. One woman came to the desk to ask about them specifically: she had received three, over the course of three separate loans, and had saved them all in a small envelope she carried in her library bag. "They make me feel looked after," she said, which was, all things considered, exactly right.

Chomp took up its new residence on a Thursday evening, on the shelf nearest the west-facing window in Aisle Seven: a spot between a nature encyclopedia and a large illustrated atlas that SPARK had identified as receiving good morning light between eight and ten AM and a pleasant evening light in late afternoon. The book Chomp chose to live in was a different one now — a well-worn anthology of short adventure stories that had been borrowed eighty-seven times and had the soft, companionable feel of a book that had been many people's friend.

It was, Chomp said, an improvement on Henderson, G.

Henderson, G. was reshelfed with the care it deserved and a small note in its front pages that said, in Alana's handwriting: This book was home to something important for thirty-one years. Treat it accordingly.

On the first morning after the move, SPARK checked on Chomp at eight fifteen.

Chomp was at the window — pressed against it, more precisely, its flat body tilted to face the glass, watching the early light come in at an angle across the shelf tops. It was not doing anything in particular. It was simply watching the day begin.

"Is it raining?" SPARK asked, because that had been the wish.

"No," Chomp said. "It's very fine, actually."

It sounded surprised. As if it had been waiting a long time to see a fine morning and had not been entirely sure fine mornings happened.

Chapter 12 — A Good Bookmark

They found Frankie on a Saturday morning, which was a day on which no one had planned to find Frankie and on which, consequently, everything that happened felt like it was in the right order.

SPARK had, on his own initiative — which he mentioned in a footnote and which none of them asked him to justify — run a search of the library's historical membership records. He was looking for a child named Frankie registered in or around 1984, give or take a year for the note's margin of uncertainty. He had found eleven possibilities in the relevant age range. Of the eleven, three had family memberships still active on the current system. Of those three, one was listed under a surname that matched a current adult cardholder who renewed their library membership every year, without fail, and whose loan history showed a lifelong preference for illustrated natural history and books about making things.

Her name was Frances Owusu, and she had been bringing her own children to the library on Saturdays since they were old enough to hold a picture book.

She was sitting in the children's section when Natalia found her, reading aloud to a small girl who was approximately four and deeply invested in the part about the hedgehog.

Natalia waited.

She waited through the hedgehog and through the subsequent chapter about the hedgehog's cousin, who was described as less sensible but more fun. When the small girl had been returned to an attending grandparent and Frances was marking her place in the picture book — with a bookmark, without looking, the automatic action of a lifelong habit — Natalia sat down in the chair beside her.

"Excuse me," Natalia said. "Are you Frankie?"

Frances Owusu looked at her.

"I haven't been called Frankie since I was nine," she said.

Natalia reached into her bag and brought out the copy she had made of the note: the uneven handwriting, the rounded letters, the line wandering uphill, the careful declaration of love for books and the instruction to give the small creature made of dark red thread a good home.

Frances Owusu looked at it for a very long time. Her face did something complicated and then settled into something simple.

"Is he still there?" she asked.

"He is," Natalia said. "He's in the adventure anthology near the west window now. He has a better view."

Frances said nothing for a moment. Then: "Did he bite very many people?"

"Some," Natalia said. "He was doing his job."

"I was nine," Frances said. "I thought if I made something that cared about the books the way I cared about them, it would help while I couldn't be there." She looked at the copy of her note. "I came back to visit him once, when I was about fourteen, and the book I put him in had been checked out. I thought he'd been lost."

"He found a new home," Natalia said. "He's been here the whole time."

They went to Aisle Seven together.

Chomp was in its spot near the window, resting between the pages of the adventure anthology, and it heard them coming because it had been in this library for forty years and knew the sound of people approaching its shelf with something different in their step.

It came to the edge of the pages.

Frances saw it and laughed — a real, brief, entirely unguarded laugh, the laugh of someone who had forgotten something and has suddenly remembered it exactly. "You're exactly as I made you," she said.

Chomp looked at Frances Owusu for a long time with its small red eyes.

"You gave me good thread," it said. "I'm still here."

Frances reached out very carefully and pressed the tip of one finger, very gently, to the top of Chomp's head. The gesture of a child who made something once with care and wanted to know it had been all right.

"I've used bookmarks ever since," she said. "Every single book. Even the ones I read in the bath."

"Good," Chomp said. "As it should be."

Maya, who had been watching from the end of the aisle, thought about a nine-year-old girl who had loved books too much to leave them unprotected, who had made something out of thread and cardboard and fierce small love and trusted it to a library, and who had now, forty years later, found it still at its post, still sharp, still serious about its purpose — a little less alone than it had been yesterday, in a spot where the morning light came in at a very fine angle and there was, at last, a view.

SPARK added a new entry to the library's supplemental records: Chomp — donation, 1984. Provenance: Frankie, age 9. Status: active. Location: Aisle Seven, west window, between adventure and atlas. Function: guardian of pages, consultant on bookmarks, and friend to those who take the books seriously.

And below that, in a smaller note he added for his own records, the way he sometimes did for things that didn't fit any official category but deserved to be written down:

Still counts as a good bookmark. Possibly the best.

THE END